

Bookend; Book Party

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Sebastian Schmidt and Raphael Sagalyn do essentially the same thing: sell books. Schmidt is a sculptor. His weightiest tome, at 265 pounds, is of greenish marble; the lightest, weighing about a pound, of ruddy sandstone. Sagalyn is an American agent who sells foreign rights to the books he represents. Both were doing what they do every year at the Frankfurt Book Fair, the international publishing world's weeklong marathon of deals, near deals and partying. Schmidt stood under a tent selling hefty volumes carved into sandstone, granite and travertine. Sagalyn was looking cramped at Table 257 in a riotously noisy hall with hundreds of other agents and editors.

This year's fair, held in mid-October, drew 6,887 exhibitors from 107 countries, including 842 publishers from the United States. To increase efficiency, Sagalyn at times adopts assembly-line methods. By 11 in the morning, he had met with a gaggle of Japanese publishers, the head of Penguin Books in London, an Argentine editor and Alan Wherry, the chief executive of Bloomsbury in the United States.

At his meeting with the Japanese, eight publishing executives, plus an interpreter, sat crowded around his card table, rapidly scanning the rights lists and capsule summaries, raising a hand when they wanted to see more. The Japanese are into self-help, so they liked the forthcoming "Power Talk," by Sarah Myers McGinty, about using language to achieve authority, and they also went for "The Future of Success," by Robert Reich (due out in January). Had they read the books? "Reading? We're reading paragraphs. This is the quest for the big book," Sagalyn said.

Across the aisle, another agent was equally frenzied. Nicholas Ellison's day had begun with breakfast at his hotel with David Young, the president of Little, Brown in Britain, which publishes Ellison's best-selling client, Nelson DeMille. "We get to have a cup of coffee and break bread," Ellison said with a touch of understatement. He had met with prospective buyers every half-hour since to hawk foreign rights to a line-up that included "Up Country," DeMille's sequel to "The General's Daughter," and "Misfortune," a first novel by Nancy Geary, a lawyer turned writer. "Misfortune," which sold last year to Warner Books for \$600,000, had already been picked up by a German publisher for \$240,000. Ellison hoped he might repeat Geary's success with another first novel, "Equivocal Death," by Amy Gutman, who also used to be a lawyer.

Except for Schmidt the sculptor, and a row of booths selling book-related trinkets, the fair consists overwhelmingly of publishers seeking to sell foreign rights. At the Bloomsbury booth, the British publisher of the "Harry Potter" series, the director, Kathy Rooney, answered with playful crossness when asked about Harry's sales. "We all admire Harry Potter," she said, "but we are publishing 250 books a year." Jonathan Glasspool, director of the reference division, said that Harry's agent was out on the floor selling the foreign rights. "It's suddenly transformed his life," Glasspool said. "He's talking to someone now about Lithuania."

If the agents hardly need manuscripts, even less do they need the authors. True, Nancy Geary was seen having wine and cheese at the booth of her French publisher, and Gore Vidal had lunch with his German publisher, Karl Blessing, to whom he boasted that, at 75, he was in "the springtime of my senility." But many publishers and agents, engrossed in their selling, were hardly aware that Czeslaw Milosz and Wislawa Szymborska, Nobel Prize-winning poets from Poland (which had a special exhibit at this year's fair), read their work at the opening ceremony. Gao Xingjian, the Chinese novelist and playwright who won this year's Nobel, held a news conference that illustrated the fair's Tower-of-Babel quality. The writer, who wore a black turtleneck and black suit and appeared slightly intimidated by the two husky bodyguards who accompanied his every step, spoke French, and was asked in German by a reporter, who used the Chinese word, to comment on the Chinese concept of "limitation." But Gao had to pass, puzzled equally by the German reporter's Chinese and an interpreter's French.

The work may be exhausting, but the editors, agents and publishers who come to Frankfurt still find the energy for successive waves of luncheons, dinners and receptions to exchange gossip and strike deals, ending up after midnight in the lobby of the Frankfurter Hof hotel. The hotel, once Hitler's favorite, was exorcised by Helen Wolff, the distinguished American editor and one of the fair's legends until her death in 1994. She never worked the floor but checked into Room 300-A, where she received editors, translators, agents and the writers she published: Italo Calvino, Stanislaw Lem, Amos Oz.

Things have changed since the giants walked the earth. Still, after hours, some serious socializing goes on in the hotel lobby and at bars and cafes all over town, which get all but taken over for the week by book people. "It sometimes goes on till 3 or 4," said Alicka Pistek, who sells foreign rights for Nicholas Ellison's

agency and who was busy chatting at one gathering with Armin Gonterman of the German publisher Ullstein, which had just acquired the rights to "Equivocal Death." "We talked about positioning the author," she said.

Earlier in the evening, Robbert Ammerlaan, the head of a Dutch publisher, De Bezige Bij (Busy Bee), spoke of the literary power of small countries like the Netherlands. "There are only 18 million Dutch, yet Donna Tartt's 'Secret History' sold 500,000 hardcover copies and 100,000 paperbacks," he said. "John Irving's 'Widow for One Year' sold 300,000 hardcovers in the States, and almost 350,000 in Holland."

Roger Straus, the president of Farrar, Straus & Giroux, who has missed only one year since he started coming to Frankfurt in 1961, spoke enthusiastically of the after-hours scene. Several years back, he bumped into a Swiss publisher at a party, and that was how he got the rights to "August 1914," Aleksandr Solzhenitsyn's novel. "I'm a blind pig hoping to find a truffle," he said. "And occasionally one does find one."

As for lunches and dinners, topping the pecking order -- in prestige, if not overall clout -- is the annual luncheon by the Holtzbrinck group (owner of Henry Holt, St. Martin's and Farrar, Straus), in which a group of about 75 invited guests gather in the opulent executive dining room on the 34th floor of the Deutsche Bank towers. But the publishing brass can be annoyingly superior, as one agent commented when describing the huge Friday evening reception at the Hotel Intercontinental by Bertelsmann (which has the clout). "The big, big heads of industry, like Napoleons, see the hoi polloi of publishing throw themselves at the buffet," as he put it.

Increasingly, squeezed profit margins and the disappearance of independent publishers into the arms of conglomerates like Bertelsmann and Holtzbrinck are the hot topics. "People have stopped talking about who's bringing out what books, but about who bought what company," said Andre Schiffrin, publisher of

the New Press. Last year, the fair's longtime director, Peter Weidhaas, retired, and concern that the event would be pushed even farther in a commercial direction prompted the appointment of Lorenzo Rudolf, the 41-year-old Swiss who revived the Basel Art Fair in the early 1990's after the burst bubble of 1980's affluence almost bankrupted it. Rudolf plans a virtual Internet book fair, and he has expanded space at the fair for electronic publishing, comic books and graphic novels.

Charles W. Rozanski, the president of Mile High Comics, a Denver comics dealer, said it was a dream come true. "At this point, the audience in Europe is the most sophisticated graphic storytelling audience in the world," he said. "I've often felt I was shouting down a well. I am so thrilled. It's a validation. It's like being a frog that's suddenly been kissed by the princess."

But then, not everyone attends Frankfurt to buy or sell, and representatives of smaller exhibitors are often shunted off to far corners of the immense fair. Far from the hubbub and ignored by most visitors was Ali A. Eljarm, the fair's sole Libyan publisher, who sat in a small booth reading. Eljarm was not selling books but representing the World Center for the Study and Research of the Green Book of Col. Muammar el-Qaddafi, which, he explained enthusiastically, is available in over 50 languages, including Chinese, Urdu and Russian.

"He is not only a leader, but a thinker," Eljarm said.